Modeling and Documenting Variation across Prinmi Varieties [Project Launch]

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▶ 1. OVERVIEW

This project launch provides an **empirical** and **theoretical** basis for sociolinguistic fieldwork on **Prinmi** (Pǔmǐ), focused on variation in **tonal inventories** and **tone spreading**

▶ 2.THE PRINMI (PǓMǏ) LANGUAGE

Sino-Tibetan Qiangic language(s) spoken in China's Southwestern provinces of Sichuan and Yunnan

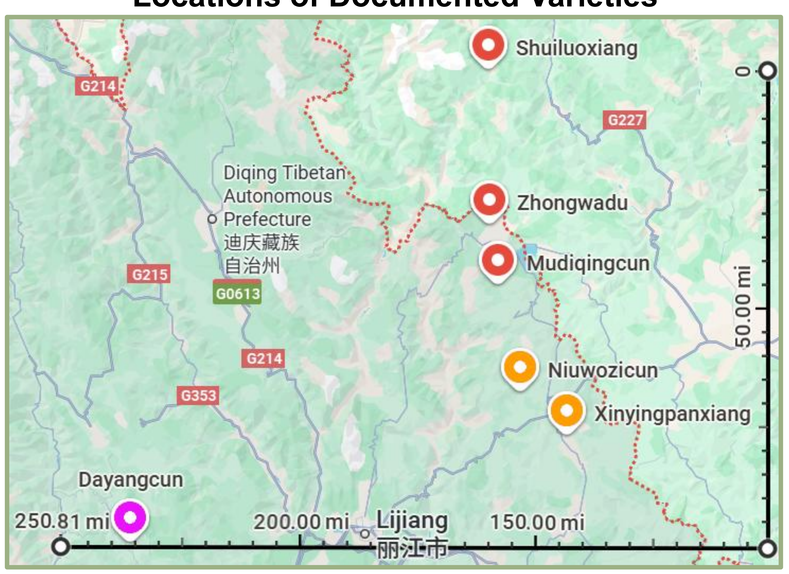
Unstandardized with high variance **across** dialects and **between** different **villages** and **clans**

Documented* Prinmi Varieties

Dialect	Variety	Source
Northern	Wadu (WDP)	Daudey, 2014
	Mudiqing & Shuiluo (MSP)	Jacques, 2011
Central	Xingyingpan & Niuwozi (XNP)	Ding, 2014
Western	Dayang (DYP)	Matisoff, 1997

*documented in English; see works cited for list of Chinese scholars

Locations of Documented Varieties



▶ 3. AXES OF VARIATION

I. Lexical tones → vary by **#** and **realization**

II. Spreading processes → vary by **#, interactions,** and likely **realization**

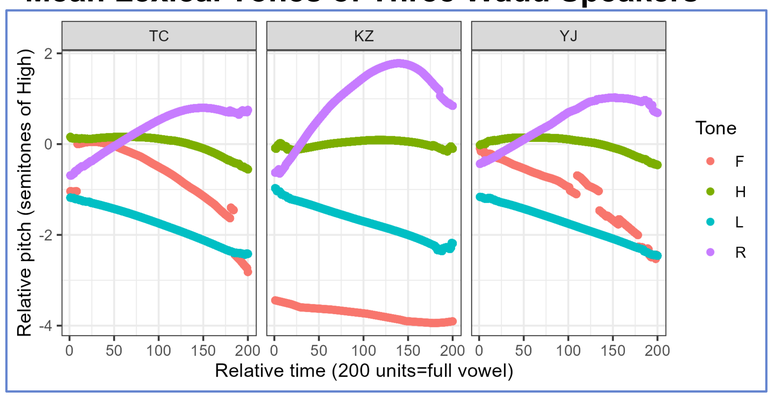
▶ LEXICAL TONES

All dialects have high tones, but…

1. Low tone either **privative** or **specified**
2. Unclear **how many** rising tones
3. Unclear if fall is **contrastive** on polysyllables

Likely **intra-varietal variation** in production

Mean Lexical Tones of Three Wadu Speakers



▶ TONE SPREADING

Two kinds of right spreading from stems to suffixes and clitics:

- **Contour Spreading (CS)** F + σ → **H.L**
- **High Tone Spreading (HTS)** H + σ → <u>H.H</u>

In Wadu & Mudiqing, CS **always feeds** HTS:
1. /R/ + /σ.σ/ → [**L-<u>H</u>**.H]

In Xingyingpan, CS **sometimes** feeds HTS:
2. /R/ + /σ.σ/ → [**L-H**.L] or [**L-<u>H</u>**.H]

Unlike Wadu, Mudiqing HTS is **unbounded**:
3. /H/ + /σ.σ.σ/ → [H-H.H.H]

Spreading is not reported for Dayang **at all**

▶ TONAL VARIATION HYPOTHESES

1. HTS realization **is shared** across varieties
2. XNP CS variably feeds HTS due to **different underlying rising tones**
3. Differences in low tone behavior result from an **older toneme** becoming **irregular**
4. Falling tone remains **contrastive for some speakers** but is **losing contrast for others**

▶ 4. RESEARCH METHODS

Collated list of **13 shared words** from documented varieties capturing **full range** of attested tones

26 stimuli created from Wadu utterances (collected by Daudey, p.c. 2025) to elicit forms with & w/o **spreading**

- Different frames for verbs vs. nouns, animate vs. inanimate

Goal is to record **10 speakers** of **WDP**, **MSP**, and **XNP** varieties performing task

▶ 5. CHALLENGES

I **don't speak Prinmi** and am barely conversational in Mandarin, so will need to employ a consultant

Prinmi **is not written**, so elicitation must be verbal and/or through a picture task or translation task

Tone spreading occurs in connected speech; this makes phonetic analysis of tone difficult (Stanford, 2016)

▶ 6. OPEN QUESTIONS

I. Is there a better task for eliciting tone spreading data? (see handout)

II. Is there a doable/easy follow-up perception task?

III. Ways to constrain scope?

IV. What have I not considered?

▶ REFERENCES